

# Therapsids

During the Permian Period, the pelycosaurs (see previous page) evolved into more mammal-like animals known as therapsids. Unlike their sprawling, lizardlike ancestors, the therapsids had a more upright build that let them run and breathe more easily, allowing a more active lifestyle. The therapsids were the ancestors of mammals and became increasingly mammal-like over time.



## FAMILY FACT FILE

### Key features

- Stout bodies
- Massive heads
- Teeth specialized to form incisors, canines, and molars
- More upright legs than their pelycosaur ancestors

### When

Therapsids appeared in the Permian Period and became the dominant animals on land. They went into decline during the age of the dinosaurs, but one family of small therapsids survived and gave rise to the mammals.

## Moschops

MOE-shops



■ **When** 255 million years ago (Late Permian)

■ **Fossil location** S. Africa

■ **Habitat** Forests

■ **Length** 8 ft (3 m)

■ **Diet** Plants

*Moschops* was a heavily built plant-eater, about the size of a bear. It had stout legs, a huge, barrel-shaped chest, and a short tail.

The bone in the top of its skull was amazingly thick. Scientists think males may have used their massive skulls as battering rams in contests over mates, as bighorn sheep do today. *Moschops* had wide jaws with short, chisel-like front teeth that met (rather than overlapping) when its mouth closed, allowing it to nip plants precisely.

▼ **EARLY HERDS?** *Remains of several Moschops individuals have been found fossilized together. Perhaps these plant-eaters lived in small herds for protection from predators.*

